

EYE CONTACT

Eye contact is treated in schools as a sign of attention, respect, and honesty. It is not reliable evidence of any of the three. In some places it is written into IEP goals and behaviour plans, and children are made to perform it.

LOOKING AWAY IS HOW WE LISTEN.

A CHILD LOOKING AWAY IS NOT BEING RUDE · THEY ARE WORKING

IT CAN HURT

Brain imaging shows eye contact overactivating a region that produces arousal and distress in Autistic people. A child who looks away is protecting themselves from pain, not showing disrespect — and demanding it anyway asks a child to hurt themselves so that an adult is more comfortable.

LOOKING AWAY IS A TOOL

Many of us can look or listen, not both at once. Gaze aversion cuts the incoming sensory load so the brain can process language and meaning. Even non-Autistic adults answer hard questions better when they look away — and children taught to use it deliberately perform better.

THE GOAL IS NOT FOR THE CHILD

An eye contact goal trains a child to perform someone else's norm for someone else's comfort. It builds no communication, no learning, no self-advocacy. What it builds is masking — and masking is linked to burnout, anxiety, depression and loss of identity.

“Eye contact — who's it for? It's not for the Autistic child. It's for the recipient. It's for their own validation.”

THINKING PERSON'S GUIDE TO AUTISM

WHAT TO DO INSTEAD

- **Do not prompt “look at me”** as a precursor to instruction.
- **Do not put eye contact in IEP goals**, behaviour plans, or compliance rubrics. Put communication, learning and self-determination there instead.
- **Do not read gaze aversion** as rudeness, defiance, or inattention.
- If a student makes eye contact, welcome it. **If they don't, welcome that too.**
- Allow looking away, movement and stimming while listening. Reduce sensory load. Give processing time.
- **Presume competence.** The child who is not looking at you is very likely paying close attention.

LOOK FOR THESE INSTEAD

- ✓ responding to questions
- ✓ participating in discussion
- ✓ demonstrating understanding
- ✓ asking questions
- ✓ completing work

A student may be **fully engaged while looking away**. Measure learning and participation — not gaze direction. Eye contact norms also vary across cultures. In many, avoiding the gaze of an authority figure is the respectful thing to do. Teaching one style as the correct one enforces a narrow norm and calls it a skill.

“We can either look like we're paying attention, or we can actually pay attention, in our way, using our tools.”

RYAN BOREN · STIMPUNKS FOUNDATION

THE PRINCIPLE

Students should not be required to perform behaviours that interfere with their ability to learn. For many Neurodivergent students, **looking away is a tool for thinking**.

Supporting that difference is not lowering expectations. It is designing environments that respect how diverse minds work.

Adapted from the *Eye Contact* Why Sheet at stimpunks.org/why/eye-contact, which carries the full sources. Key reading: Nouchine Hadjikhani (Harvard Medical School) on overstimulation rather than indifference; “Should We Insist on Eye Contact...” (Indiana Institute on Disability and Community); Judy Endow, “Autism and Eye Contact”; “Eye Contact: For The Recipient's Validation Only” (Thinking Person's Guide to Autism); Doherty-Sneddon et al. on gaze aversion and teaching (*British Journal of Developmental Psychology*). Related: Monotropism, Deep Attention, Sensory Load, Processing Time, Masking Pressure — stimpunks.org/patterns.